

1. Air Is Stuff

Crush a can with nothing

It has mass, it pushes, and it pushes hard

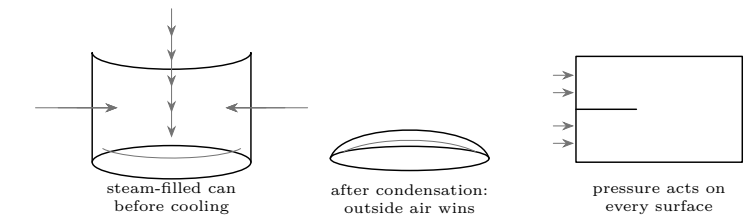
Lesson 1 · about 60 minutes · everyone — kitchen care only

What you need

- Empty aluminium drink cans
- Tongs, a hob, a bowl of iced water
- A boiled egg, peeled, and a glass bottle it will not quite fit into
- A drinking glass, card, water
- A balloon and a plastic bottle
- Bathroom scales, a bicycle pump with a gauge

Predict first

Put a tablespoon of water in an empty can, boil it until steam pours out, then turn the can upside down into iced water. What happens, and *how fast*? Write both down. Then: how much does the air in the room weigh?



Do it

Between trials. The adult removes the can from heat, turns the hob off, and confirms every item is stable. Wait until hot items are safe to handle, clear failed materials, and say “bench reset” before beginning the next numbered trial.

1. **Crush the can.** A tablespoon of water in the can, on the hob until steam is streaming out for a good ten seconds. Then, with tongs, invert it into iced water. It collapses instantly and loudly. Nothing touched it.
2. **The glass of water.** Fill a glass to the brim, lay a card over it, invert. The card stays put and the water does not fall out. Air is pushing *up* on it.
3. **Turn it sideways.** Rotate the inverted glass slowly. The card stays on at every angle, so the push is not gravity and it is not downward — pressure acts in every direction at once.
4. **The egg in the bottle.** Drop a burning strip of paper into the bottle and sit the peeled egg on the neck. As the flame goes out and the gas cools, the egg is pushed in.
5. **Read pressure safely.** Read a bicycle tyre gauge within its instructions. Use that gauge pressure only in a paper force calculation; never pressurize PVC or an improvised vessel.

What it means

Air has mass	Roughly 1.2kg per cubic metre. The air in an ordinary bedroom weighs about as much as a small child — something like 50kg. It is easy to forget because you are floating in it.
And therefore pressure	The column of atmosphere above you presses at about 14.7 psi, or 101 kPa — roughly 10 tonnes on a square metre. You do not notice because it presses equally on every side of you.
Nothing sucks	The can was not sucked in. Steam drove the air out, then condensed to a few drops of water, leaving very little inside — and the ordinary outside air pressure, no longer balanced, crushed it. There is no such thing as suction; there is only pressure on one side that is not matched on the other.
The shared idea	A pressure difference can produce force. The can does not predict a combustion transient or certify a launcher.
The number that matters	On a 3 in bore, one atmosphere of <i>extra</i> pressure is about 100 lb of force. That is why a modest pressure moves a heavy potato fast.

Break it

More water	Try a whole cup in the can instead of a spoonful. Does it crush harder, or not at all? Why might too much water be worse?
No ice	Invert into room-temperature water. The effect is weaker. What does that tell you about how fast the steam needs to condense?
A steel can	Try a food tin. Nothing happens. The force is the same — so what changed?
Do the arithmetic	Area of a 3 in circle is about 7 in ² . At 14.7 psi that is over 100 lb of force from ordinary air. Now imagine three atmospheres.

The link to the launcher
Half the fuel in your launcher is already in the chamber and it is free: the oxygen in the air. Lesson 2 is about how much of it there is and why that sets exactly how much hairspray you may use. The pressure that ordinary air already exerts is the baseline that everything in Lesson 3 is measured against.

Measurement and acceptance

Trial	Changed variable	Observation	Uncertainty / alternative
Can 1			
Can 2			
Card	orientation		
Gauge	repeated reading		

Troubleshoot
If the can does not collapse, did steam displace the air, was inversion fast, and was the water cold? Which observation supports each answer? Why is gauge pressure different from absolute pressure?

ACCEPTANCE GATE
Pass only when the learner distinguishes pressure from force, gauge from absolute pressure, and analogy from launcher approval.

Telos. Potato Launcher — 1. Air Is Stuff. Revised 20260725.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.